



WESTMINSTER ASTRONOMICAL SOCIETY, INC. (WASI)



WASI Update



WASI Update—October 2026

Contact the Secretary at secretary@westminsterastro.org

Our **membership meeting** will be **October 14** at Bear Branch Nature Center. The meeting will start with a short presentation about radio astronomy. After that, although the new generation of revolutionary "smart scopes" have built-in catalogs and "GoTo" capabilities, not everyone owns one. Those with traditional instruments must use charts, their knowledge of the heavens, a little elbow grease and a good finder scope for locating faint objects. But there is another method, drifting, which provides a reliable process for finding faint deep sky objects using nearby easy-to-find stars, or even other deep sky objects, for locating them. Curtis Roelle will describe the Drifting method at the meeting. (Note: This is a repeat of a presentation given in 2022.)

After the presentation, members shall be given an opportunity to share their images and travel experiences from both August eclipses: 1) A solar eclipse (total eclipse was visible in Europe) and 2) A very deep partial lunar eclipse. Images can be shared from attendees' laptops and cell phones by dial in for the ZOOM! meeting.

October 10 is our monthly planetarium show and **star party** at Bear Branch Nature Center. And the **member-only star party** there is **October 9-11**. The new moon is the **10th**.

WASI Second Vice President Jeff Kretsch will be organizing some telescope clinics to help people get the most out of their equipment. He could use some help. For example, you might be accomplished at using the SkyMeadeCelestron AstroSeekerOrigin; share your expertise with others who have the same gear. Contact Jeff at jlkretsch@verizon.net.

We're looking for volunteers to present at upcoming membership meetings about, well, anything of astronomy interest. Maybe meteor showers, demos of your equipment, items of historical interest, the science of astronomy, etc. The sky is the limit (so to speak). Email Laurie to volunteer: treasurer@westminsterastro.org.

- *Retired astronomers don't age—they just redshift.*
- *Retirement is great: now you can stare into space professionally again.*
- *Retirement: when your calendar becomes as empty as intergalactic space.*
- *Retired astronomers don't slow down—they just cool down like a white dwarf.*
- *Retirement turns you into a pulsar: slow, steady, and oddly predictable.*

Outreach Events

WASI holds many events to introduce the public to the wonders of the night sky. We're always looking for members to help out with these. It's fun and who knows... you might encourage a youngster to become the next Carl Sagan. Questions? Email president@westminsterastro.org.

Here's this month's calendar. If you go to the calendar web page (<https://nightsky.jpl.nasa.gov/events/wasi/>) and click on an event it will give more details.

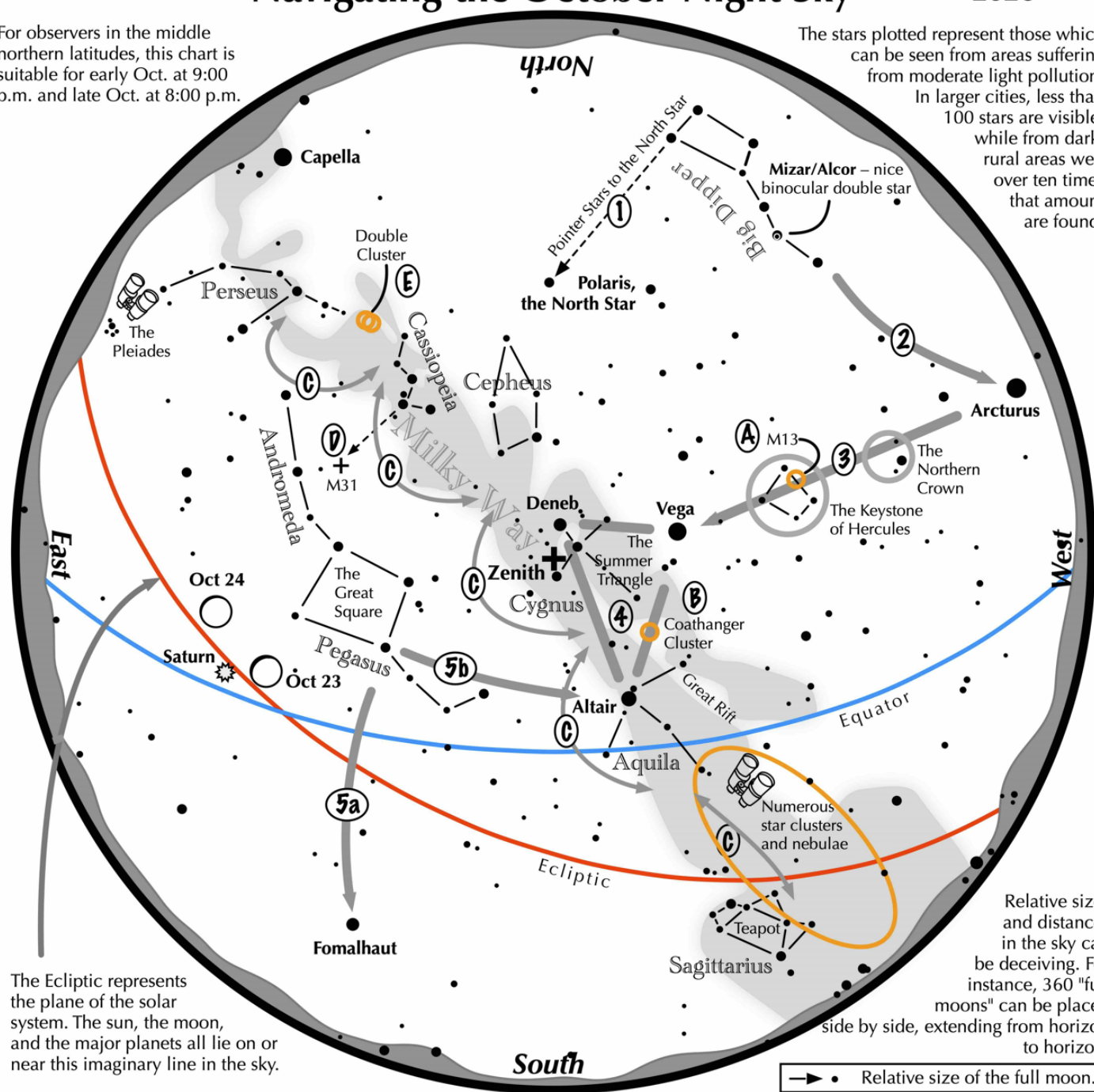
< October 2026 >						
Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
27 06:58 PM Sunset	28	29	30	01	02	03 08:00 PM Cunningham Falls Night 02:00 PM Cunningham Falls Day
04 05:00 PM Officers' Meeting 06:48 PM Sunset	05	06	07	08	09	10
11 Members' Observing 06:34 PM Sunset	12	13	14	15	16	17
18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25 06:15 PM Sunset	26	27	28	29	30	31
			06:30 PM FINKSBURG PUBLIC LIBRARY		01:45 PM HAMPSTEAD ES ASTRO PROG	

Navigating the October Night Sky

2026

For observers in the middle northern latitudes, this chart is suitable for early Oct. at 9:00 p.m. and late Oct. at 8:00 p.m.

The stars plotted represent those which can be seen from areas suffering from moderate light pollution. In larger cities, less than 100 stars are visible, while from dark, rural areas well over ten times that amount are found.



Navigating the October night sky: Simply start with what you know or with what you can easily find.

- 1 Extend a line north from the two stars at the tip of the Big Dipper's bowl. It passes by Polaris, the North Star.
- 2 Follow the arc of the Dipper's handle. It intersects Arcturus, the brightest star in the early October evening sky.
- 3 To the northeast of Arcturus shines another star of the same brightness, Vega. Draw a line from Arcturus to Vega. It first meets "The Northern Crown," then the "Keystone of Hercules." A dark sky is needed to see these two dim stellar configurations.
- 4 Nearly overhead lie the summer triangle stars of Vega, Altair, and Deneb.
- 5 High in the east are the four moderately bright stars of the Great Square. Its two southern stars point west to Altair. Its two western stars point south to Fomalhaut.

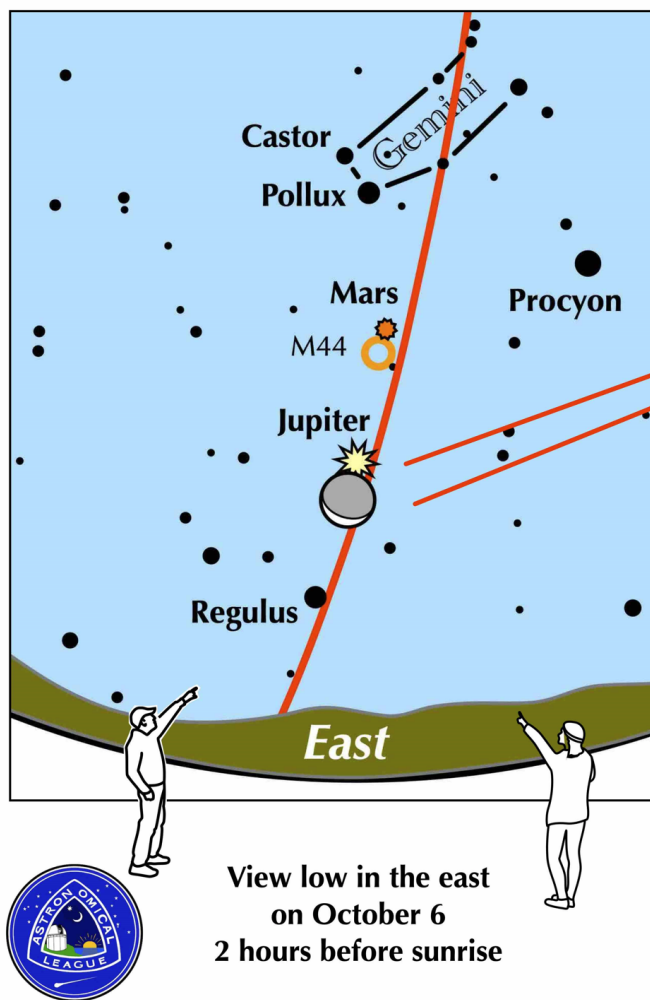
Binocular Highlights

A: On the western side of the Keystone glows the Great Hercules Cluster, a ball of 500,000 stars. **B:** 40% of the way between Altair and Vega, twinkles the "Coathanger," a group of stars outlining a coathanger. **C:** Sweep along the Milky Way for an astounding number of fuzzy star clusters and nebulae amid many faint glows and dark bays, including the Great Rift. **D:** The three westernmost stars of Cassiopeia's "W" point south to M31, the Andromeda Galaxy, a "fuzzy" oval. **E:** Between the "W" of Cassiopeia and Perseus lies the Double Cluster.

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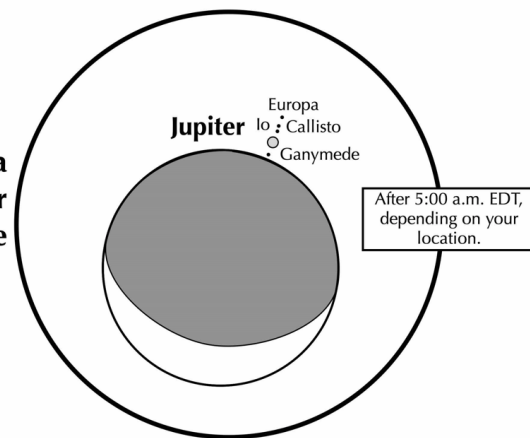


In the early morning of October 6, try this challenge:



**View low in the east
on October 6
2 hours before sunrise**

**View through a
very low power
telescope**



**Moon occults Jupiter for the eastern US.
For the rest of us, it lies very close to Jupiter**

On the morning of October 6, the moon appears very close to Jupiter.

For those in the eastern half of the US, the planet and its Galilean satellites fully emerge from occultation after 5:00 a.m. The exact time depends on observing location.

Those in the western US see Jupiter immediately next to the dark edge of the crescent moon.

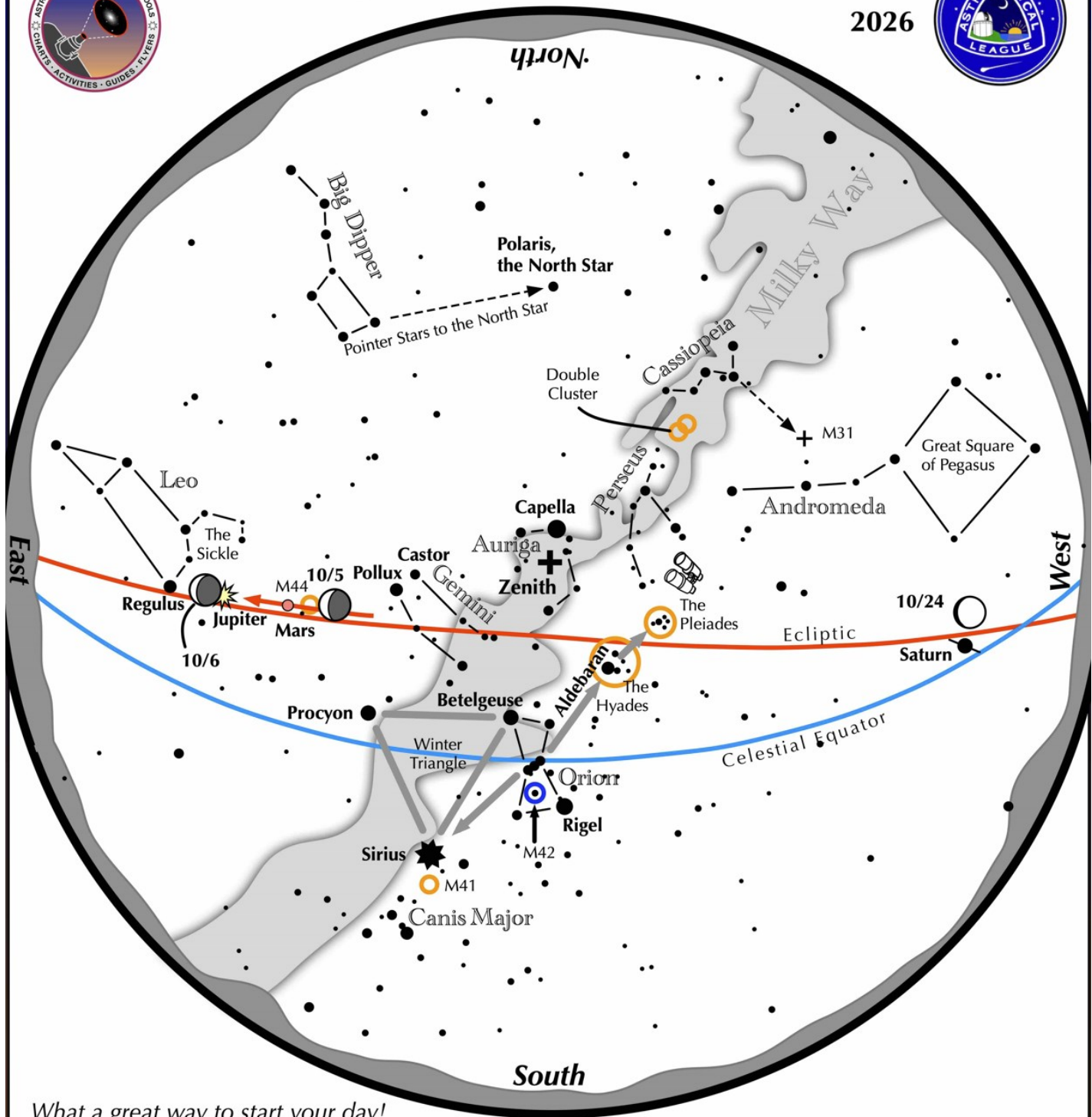
About 5:35 a.m. EDT, Ganymede's shadow begins transiting the planet. It lasts until 9:15 a.m. EDT. Its exit can be seen by west coast telescope users.

And Mars can be found approaching the Beehive star cluster.



Navigating the mid October Morning Sky

2026



What a great way to start your day!

For observers in the middle northern latitudes, this chart is suitable for mid October at 5:00 a.m.

Late sunrises in October provide opportunities for early morning skywatching.

- Bright Jupiter shines high in the east.
- Crescent moon lies just west of Mars on October 5.
- The crescent moon glows next to and occults bright Jupiter on October 6.
- The near full moon glows in the west next to Saturn on October 24.
- During the first half of October, gaze high in the south and overhead to see these many celestial features: the Pleiades, the Hyades with Aldebaran, Orion, Capella and Auriga, the Winter Triangle with Sirius and Procyon, Gemini, and, in the east, Jupiter.

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